



Days Matter as a Reminder System

Starting Point

From Remembering Dates to Understanding Dates

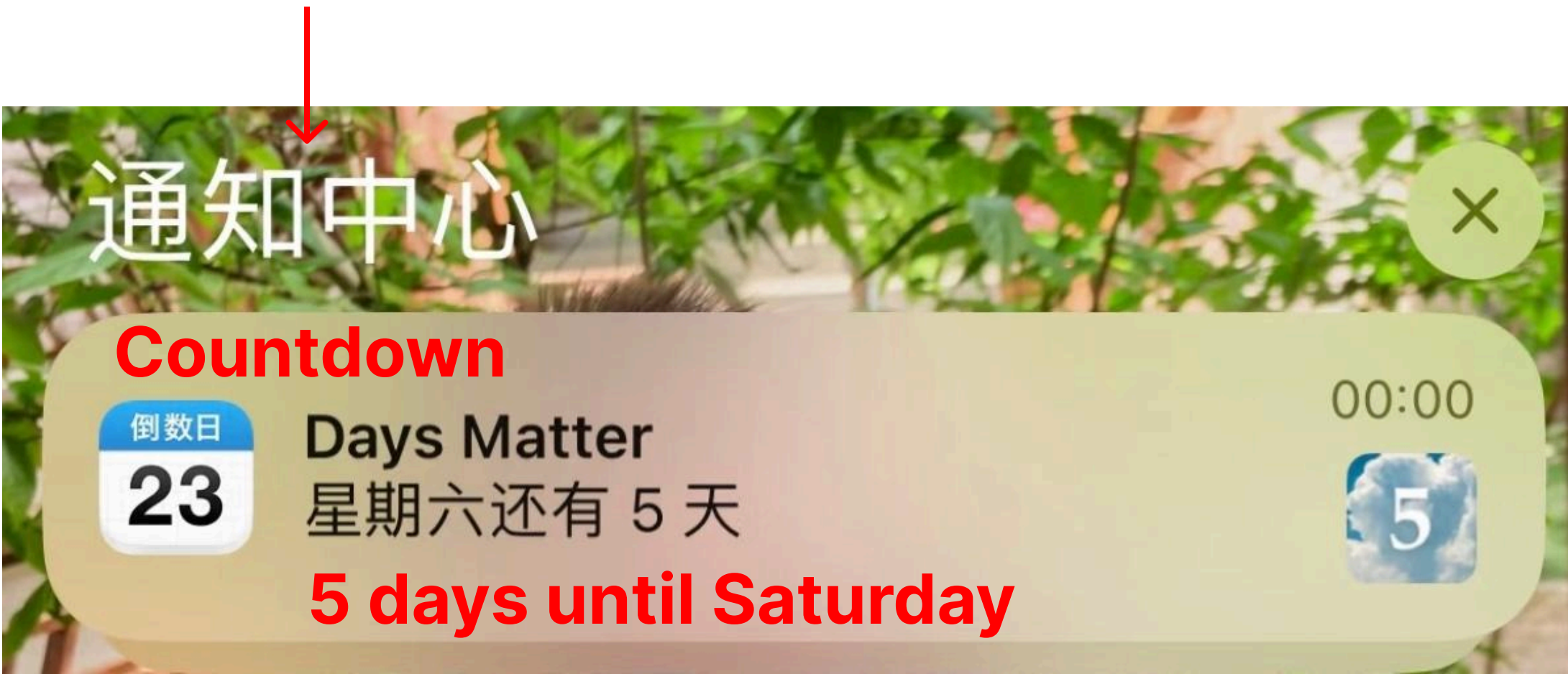
I started with Days Matter, a date-tracking app that remembers dates and reminds users about them. What interested me was that the system can remember an important date without understanding why that date matters.



Starting Point

From Remembering Dates to Understanding Dates

Notification Center

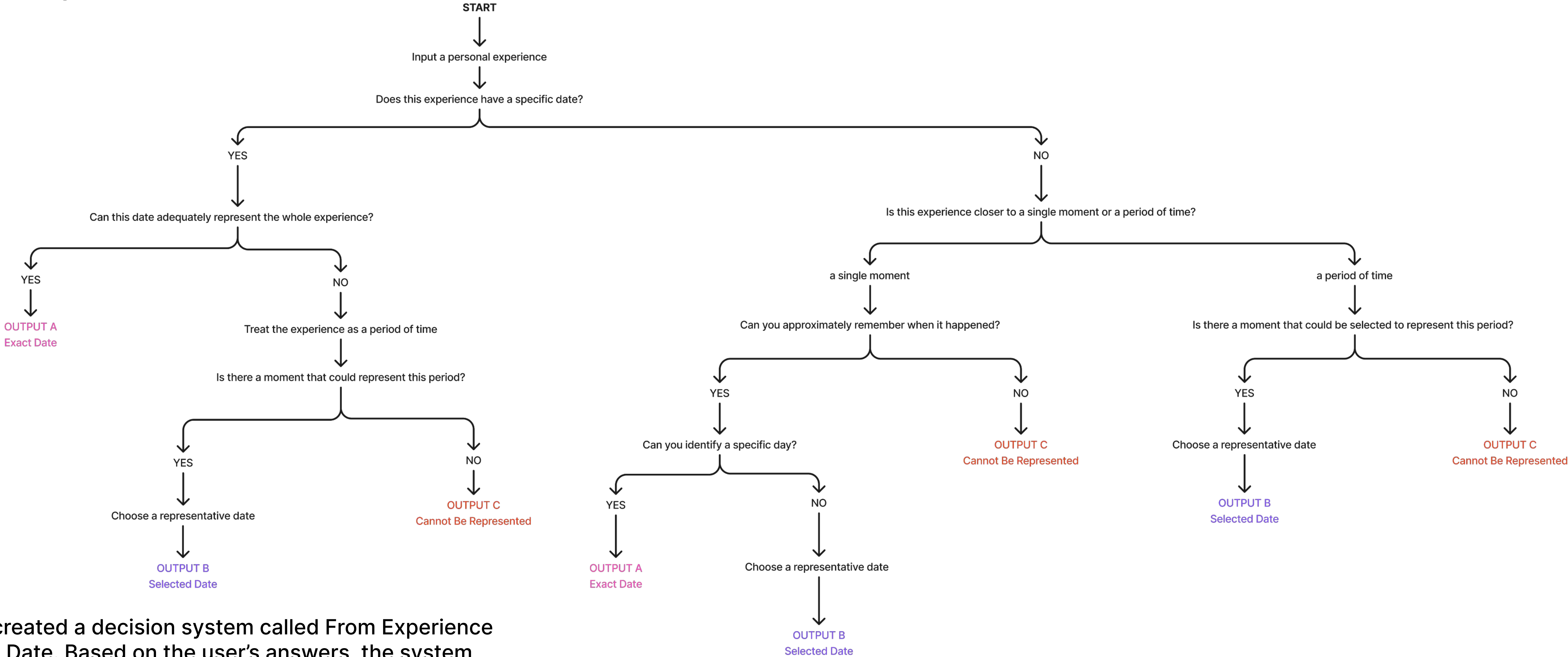


This led me to look at a step that happens before the app can calculate anything: how a personal experience becomes a date that a system can process.

If importance comes from the user and the reminder comes from the app, at what point does the “intelligence” emerge?

Reconstruction

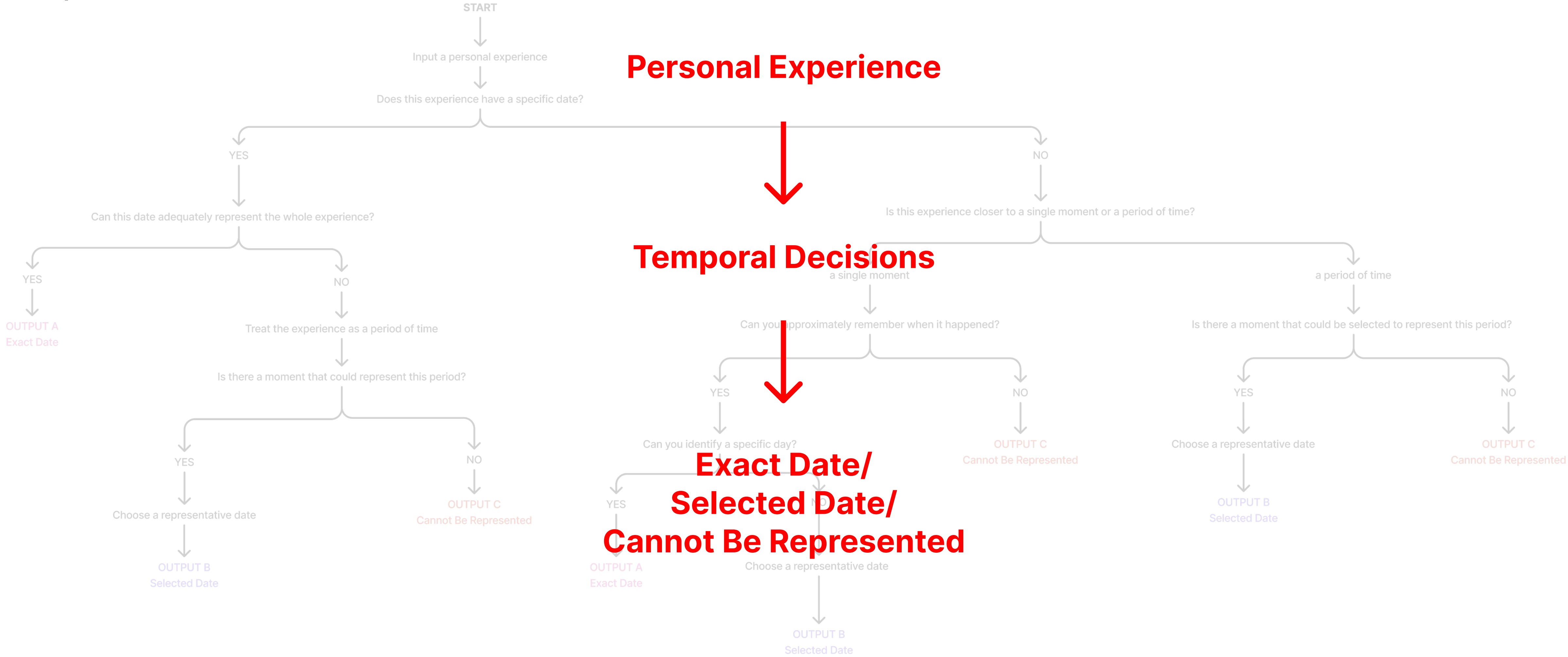
From Experience to Date



I created a decision system called From Experience to Date. Based on the user’s answers, the system gradually narrows the possible time range and produces one of three outcomes: Exact Date, Selected Date, or Cannot Be Represented.

Reconstruction

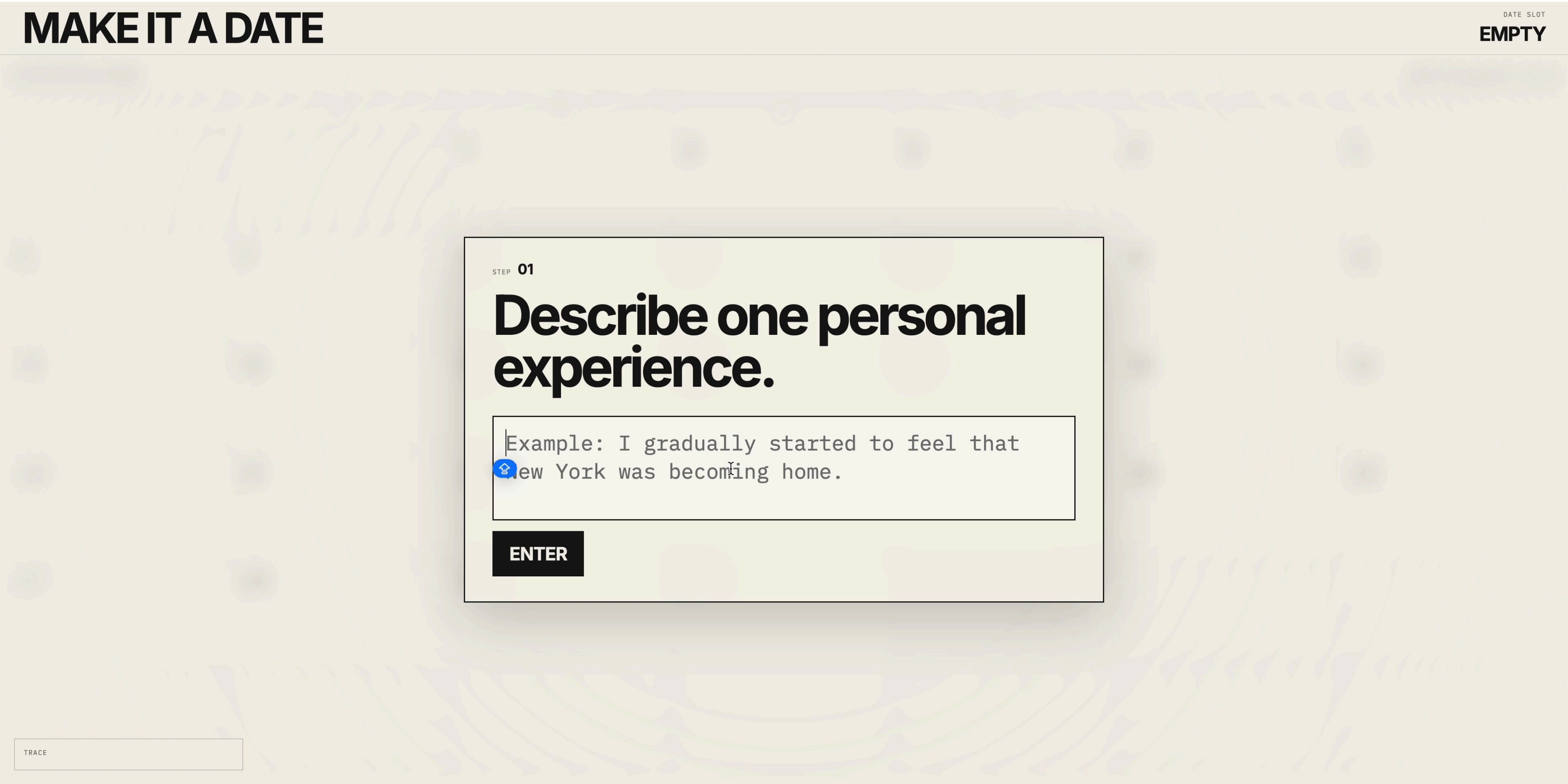
From Experience to Date



This made me realize that dates that look equally precise in a calendar can actually represent very different levels of certainty.

Intervention

Same System, Different Interface



Version 1

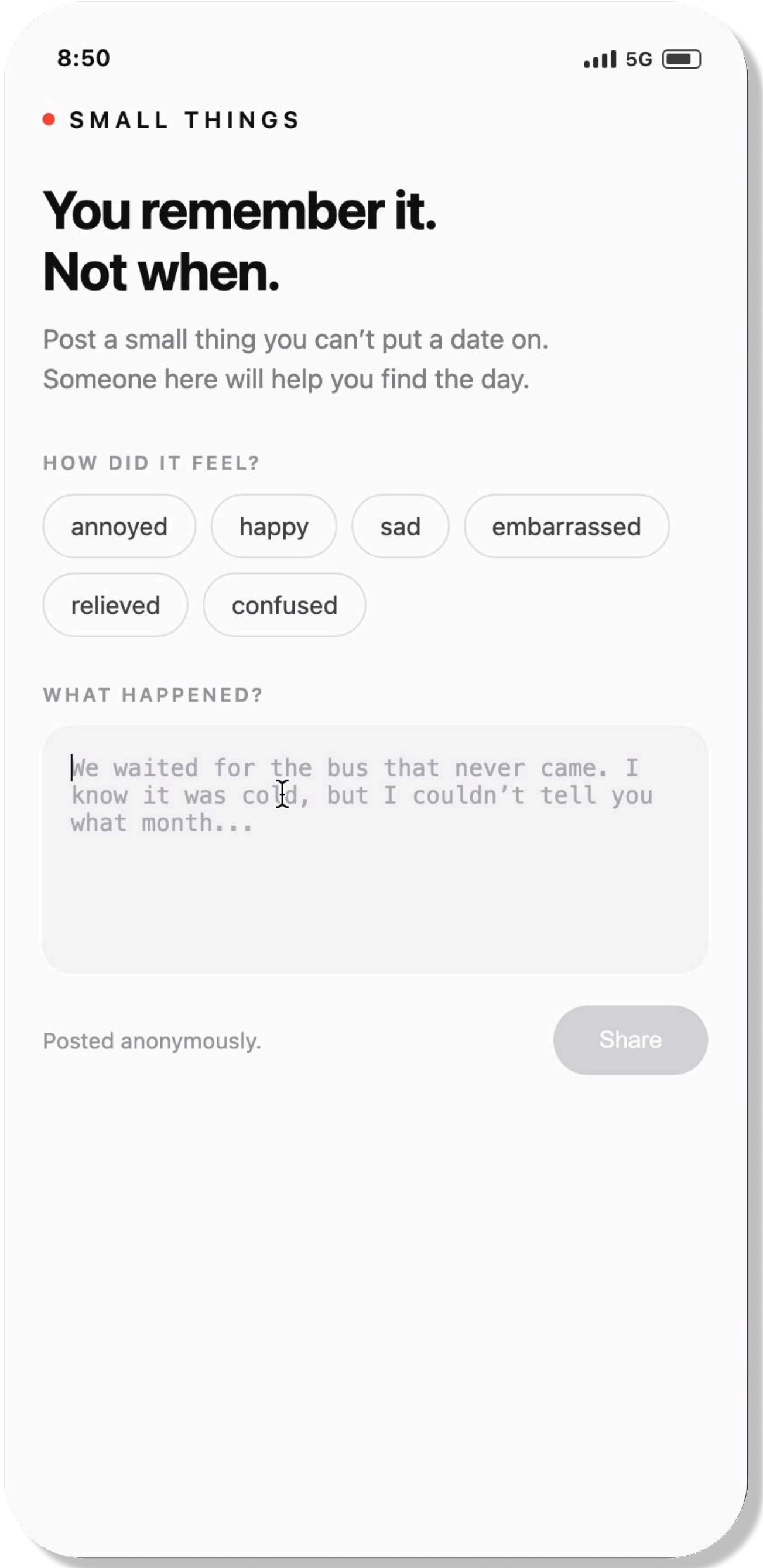
- Mechanism exposed
- decision tree visible
 - calendar visible
 - narrowing visible
 - rules legible

Version 1 exposed the mechanism.
The user could see the questions, previous
answers, and the calendar narrowing over time.

Intervention

Same System, Different Interface

Version 2 hides the same mechanism inside an anonymous chat. An anonymous account asks for clues through conversation and gradually helps the user narrow down when the experience happened.



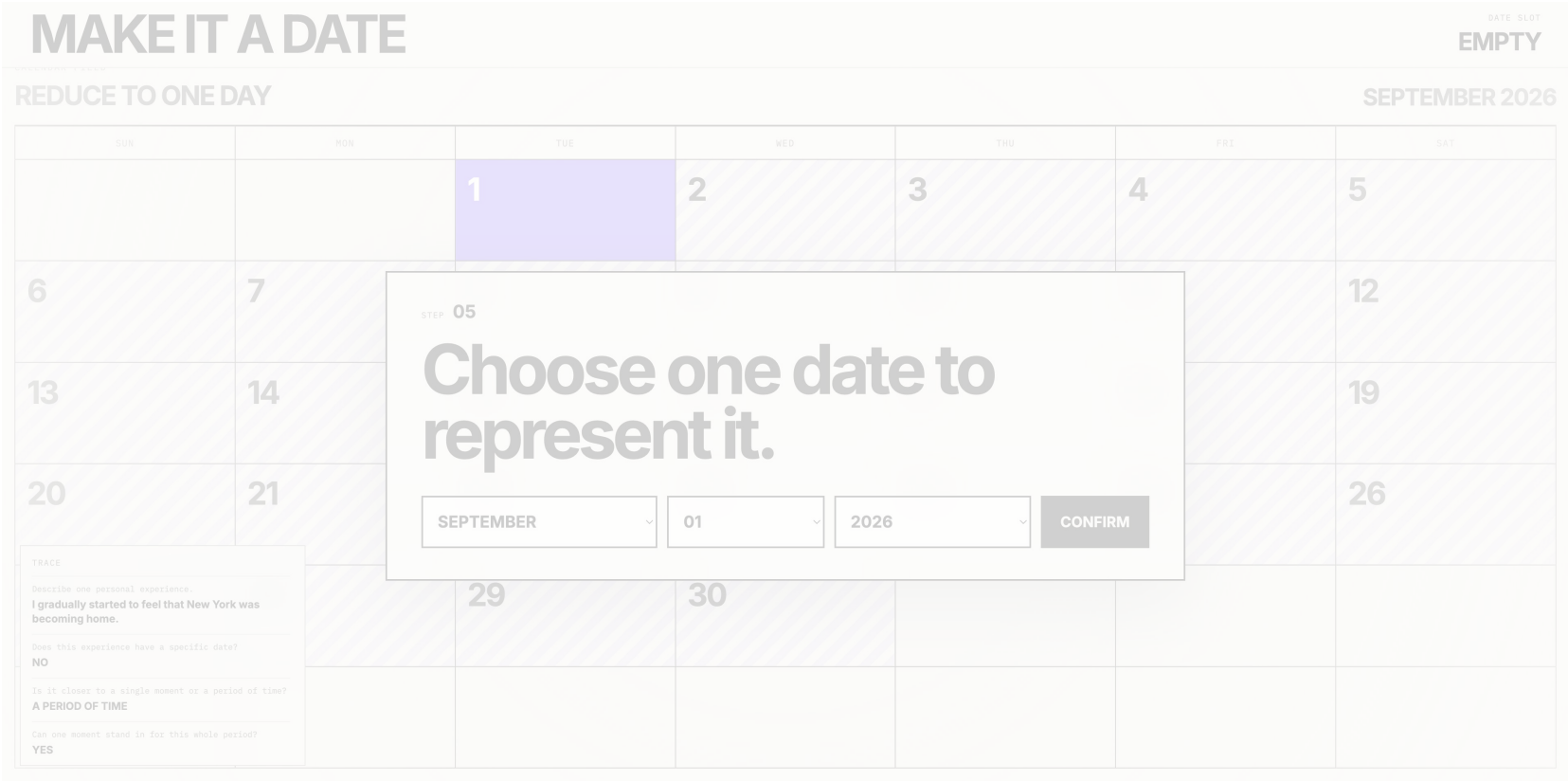
Version 2

Mechanism obscured

- anonymous chat
- natural language
- rules hidden
- same underlying system

Observation

What changed in the behavior or interpretation?



EXPOSED

- easier to understand
- predictable
- less frustrating
- clearly rule-based

More understandable
did not always mean
more human-like or
more intelligent.



OBSCURED

- more conversational
- unpredictable
- more human-like
- felt like it was “analyzing”

Final Version

Finding a Middle Ground

MAKE IT A DATE

DATE SLOT
EMPTY

REDUCE TO ONE DAY

SEPTEMBER 2026

SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT
		1	2	3	4	5
6	7					12
13	14					19
20	21					26
		29	30			

STEP 05

Choose one date to represent it.

SEPTEMBER012026CONFIRM

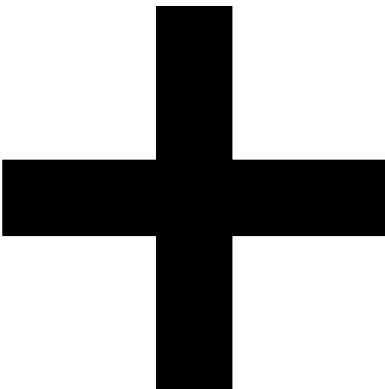
TRACE

Describe one personal experience.
I gradually started to feel that New York was becoming home.

Does this experience have a specific date?
NO

Is it closer to a single moment or a period of time?
A PERIOD OF TIME

Can this moment stand in for this whole period?
YES



11:54

5G

unknown

Active 4h ago

is there anything with pictures this day

a ticket, a photo, somebody's birthday, a deadline

yes, a photo

what day was it

ok

hold on

i think we have the exact day.

EXACT DATE
September 12, 2025
Friday

that one was yours. you had it the whole time

unknown deactivated their account.

sep 12

Seen

This account is no longer available.

see your post

start over

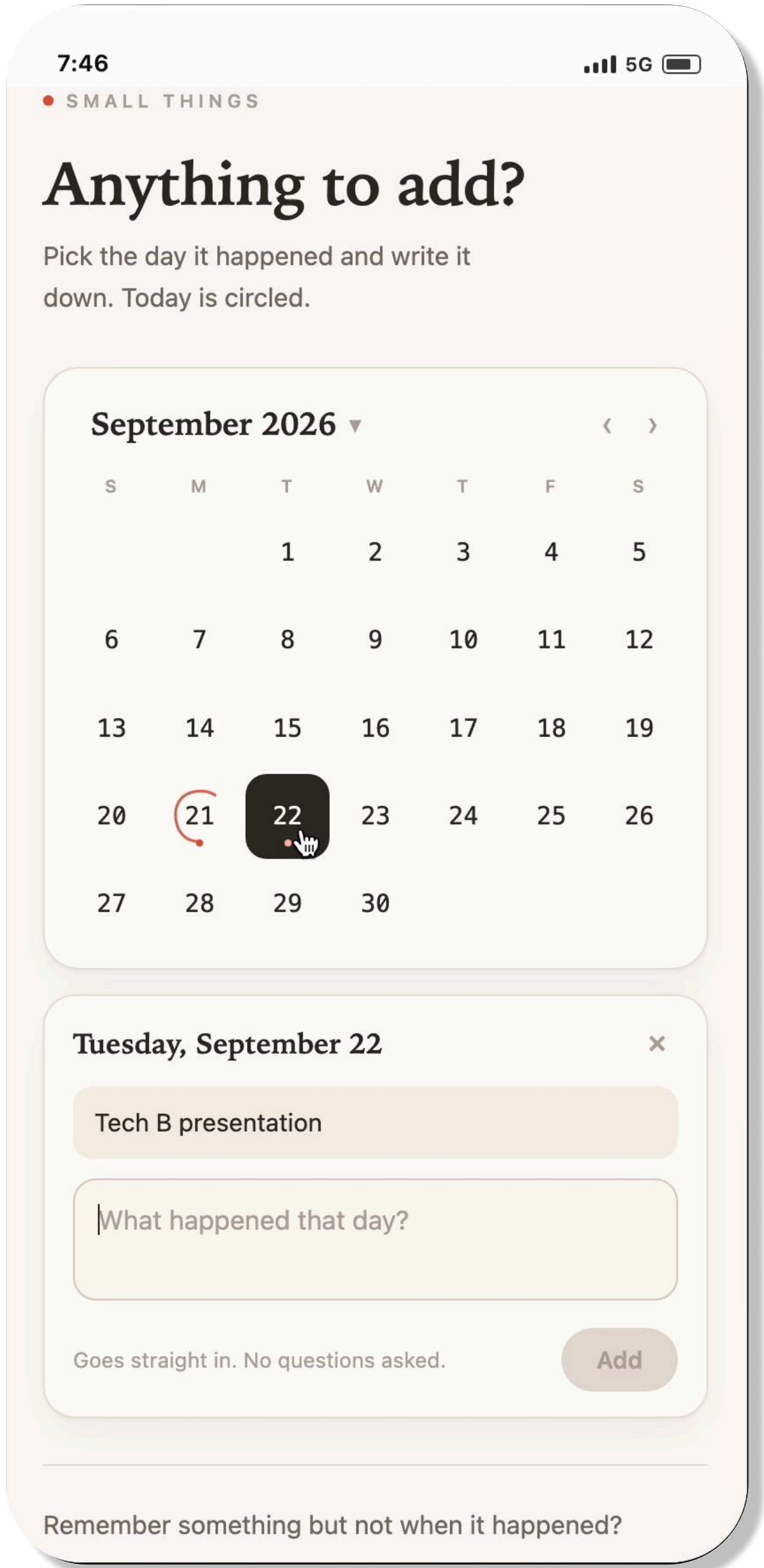
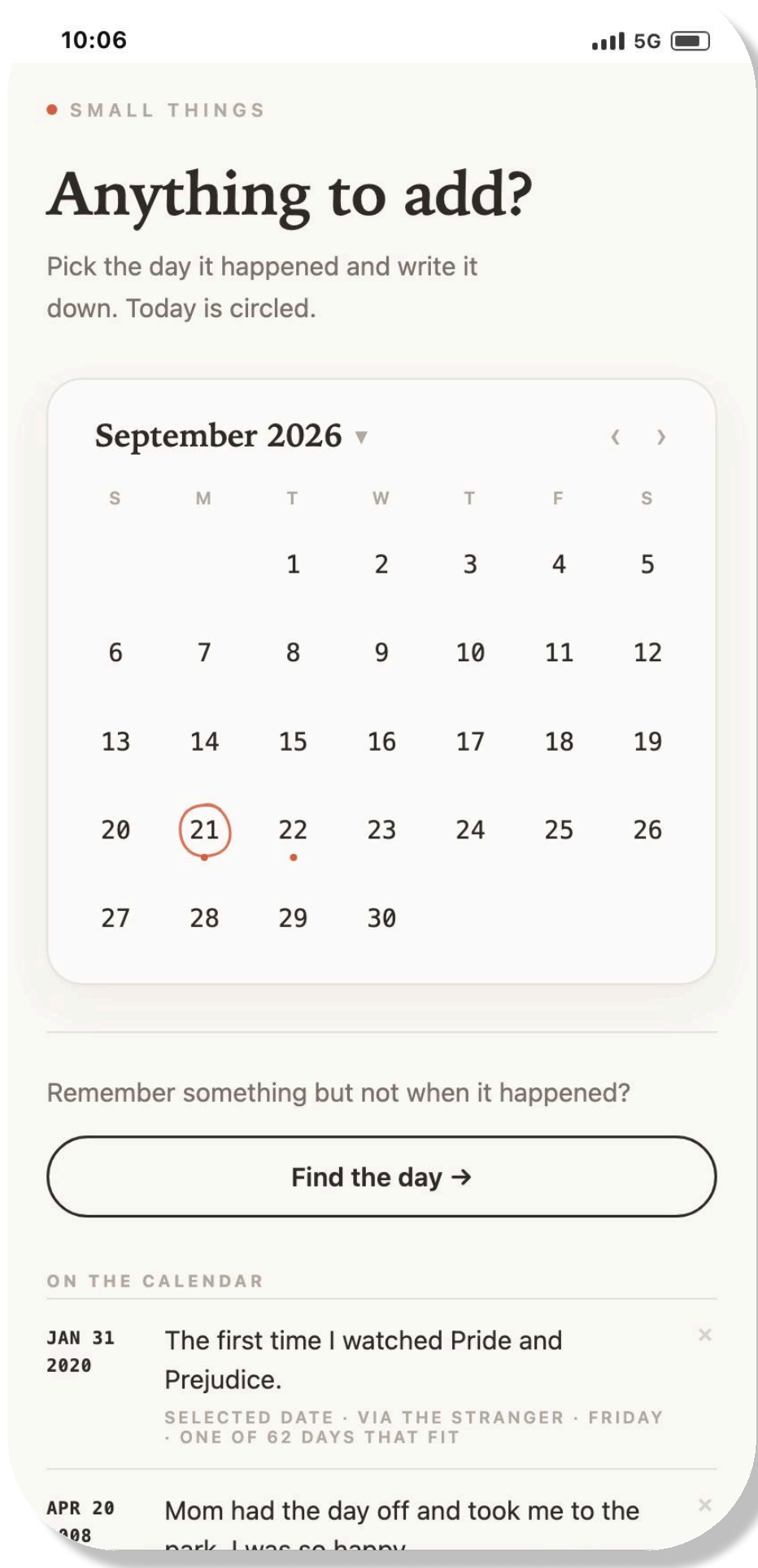


So I didn’t want the final version to be either completely transparent or completely opaque. I wanted to find a middle ground where users can understand what the system is doing without seeing every rule behind it.

Final Version

Finding a Middle Ground

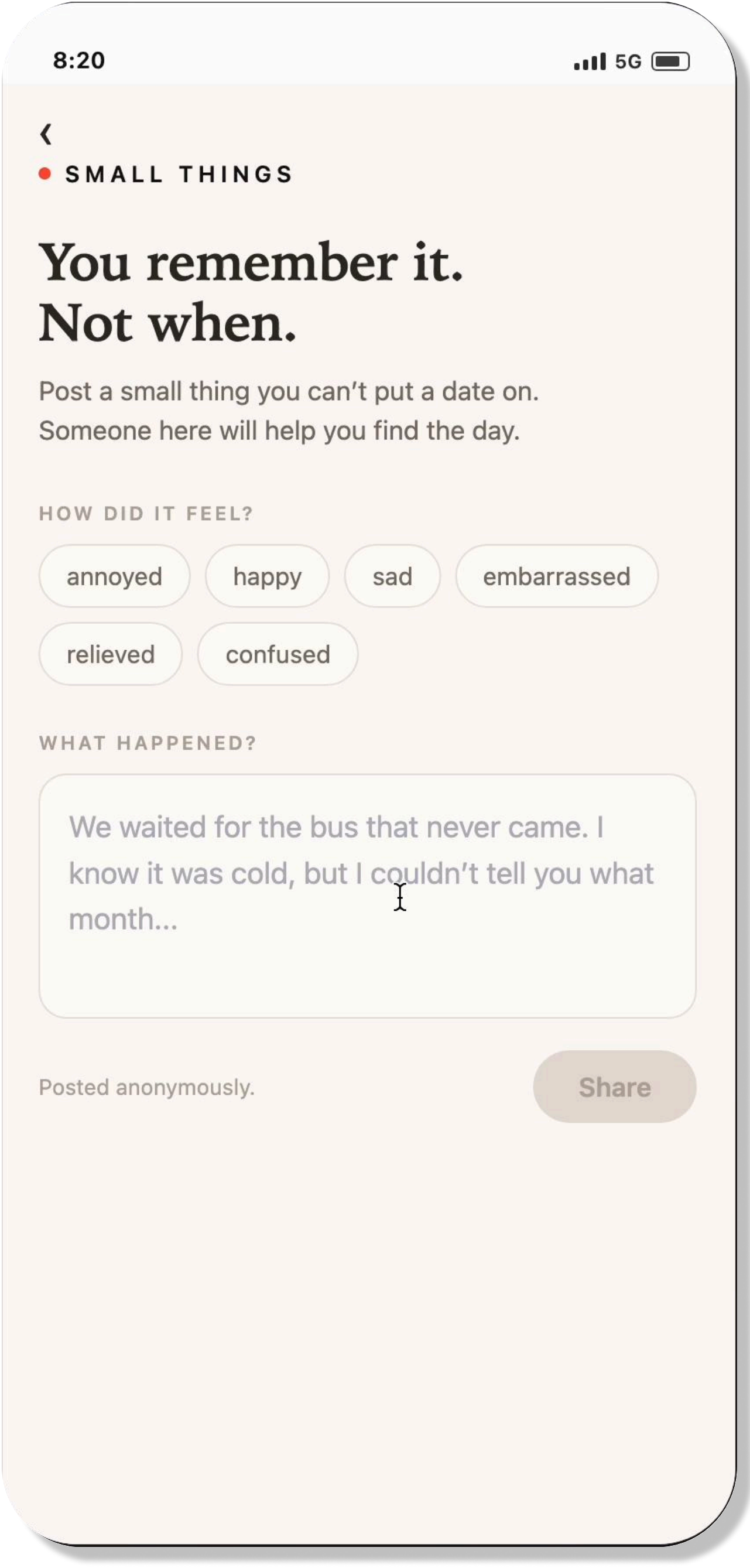
In the final version, I first separated two different situations. If the user already knows the date, they can simply add the experience to the calendar. If they remember an experience but do not know when it happened, they can enter Find the Day and talk with the anonymous account.



Final Version

Finding a Middle Ground

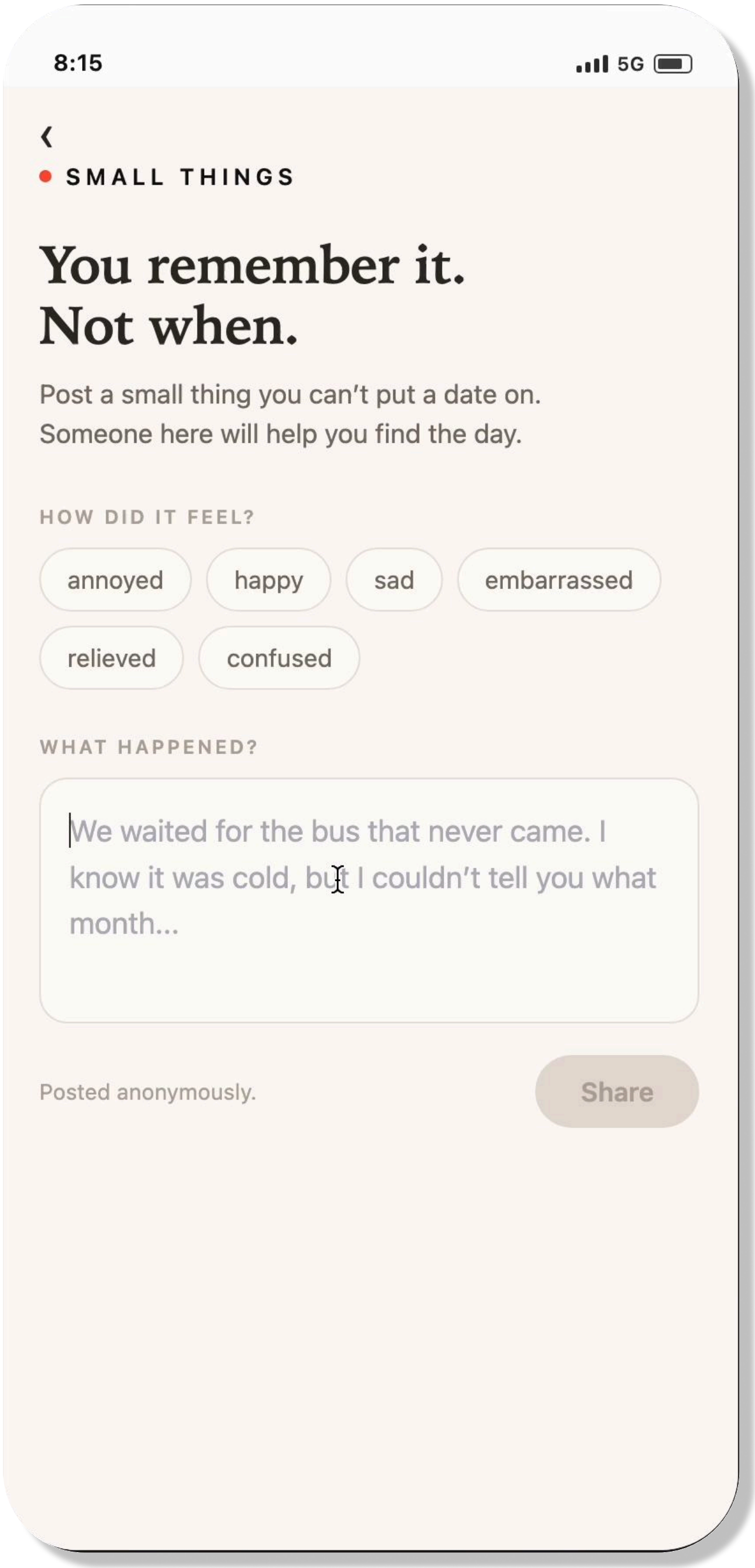
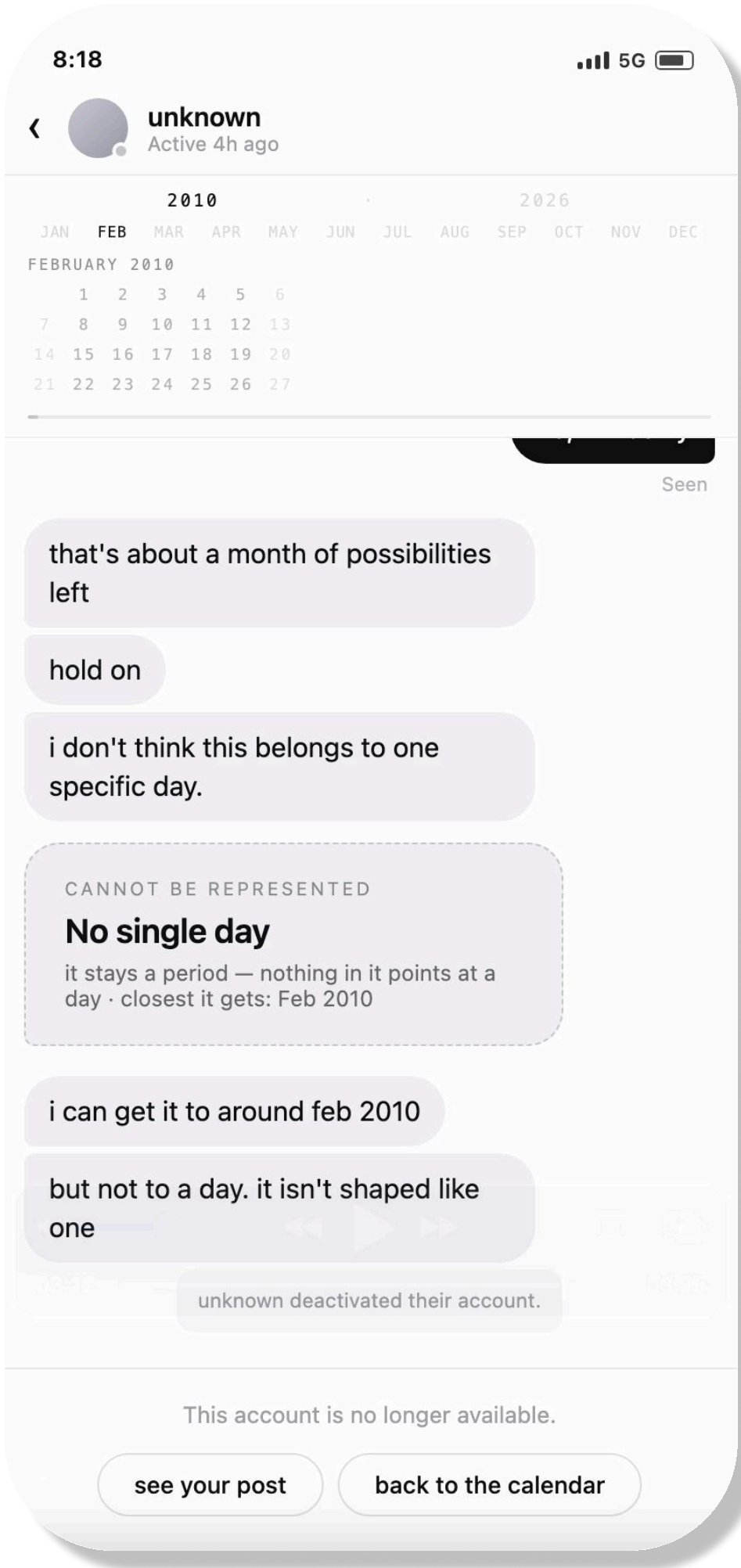
I also brought the calendar into the conversation. As the user gives more clues, the calendar above the chat updates in real time and gradually narrows the possible time range. So the user can see how the system’s understanding is changing, without seeing the exact rule behind each decision. For example, if they say the experience happened on a weekend, the calendar removes the weekdays without explaining that filtering rule directly.



Final Version

Finding a Middle Ground

The final language also depends on how the date was reached.
If the user already knew the date, the system acknowledges that it came from the user. If the system narrowed the field to one day, it describes that differently. And if there is not enough evidence, it can refuse to invent a date.



Claim

What does this reveal?

Main insight:

Perceived intelligence is shaped by how a system handles and communicates uncertainty. A system can distinguish between what it knows, what it infers, and what it still cannot determine. How much of that reasoning is shown to the user also changes how intelligent the system seems.

Evidence

My system distinguishes between an Exact Date, a Selected Date, and an experience that Cannot Be Represented by one day. In the playtest, people also read hesitation, refusal, and apparent analysis as signs of intelligence.

Limit

The prototype does not test whether the system actually understands. It tests how people interpret its behavior.

Unresolved question

When does showing uncertainty make a system seem more intelligent, and when does it make it seem less capable?